sex of this new Indian citizen was; were it male, odds-on that it was named Jawaharlal.

Women adored Jawaharlal Nehru—Brahmin women, working-class women, Hindu and Muslim and Christian and Parsi women. When Nehru was in his pomp, very many Indian men admired him too. Take your mind further back a decade, to the early days of that momentous year in Indian history, 1942. Mahatma Gandhi had convened a meeting of the Congress Working Committee at his ashram in Wardha. These were very troubled times, with the world at war, and India still denied its freedom. After the meeting ended, Jawaharlal Nehru prepared to catch the train back to his home town, Allahabad. As he turned to leave, Gandhi's wife, Kasturba, wished him Godspeed. (The account we have of this encounter is in English—she probably said, in Hindustani, '*Ishwar tera saath dé*.') At the mention of the Almighty the socialist and radical exploded. What kind of God is this, said Nehru, who allows a barbarous war, who permits the gassing of the Jews, who encourages the predations of imperialism and colonialism? There was a hushed and appalled silence all around. For, no self-described follower of Gandhi had ever spoken so harshly to the revered old lady, who was, in a manner of speaking, the Mother of the Nation-in-the-Making. The situation was retrieved by the Mahatma. 'Let Jawaharlal be, Ba,' he remarked, 'despite what he has just said, he is closer to God than any of us.'

Once more, it must have sounded better in its original Hindustani. (Here is a try: '*Usko rehné do*, Ba, *wo hum sabsé Ishwar ké nikat hai*.') It sounds evocative enough in English. What Gandhi meant was that as a person of decency and charm, a patriot of integrity and commitment, Nehru more closely approximated the moral virtues that men of faith often profess but less often practise.

II

It is safe to say that no modern politician had anywhere near as difficult a job as Jawaharlal Nehru's. At Independence, the country he was asked to